

For Immediate Release: August 29, 2024

Contact: Ian Newman, ian.newman@seiu521.org - 516 983 9839



Monterey County's Largest Union Reaches Agreement on 12% Wage Increases, Cesar Chavez Paid Holiday, & Increased County Contributions to Healthcare Plans

The Tentative Agreement Averts A Strike Vote That Started on Tuesday; County Workers Will Vote to Ratify Agreement Next Week

Monterey County, CA – The union representing over 3,500 county workers including social and behavioral health workers, roads and maintenance, 9-1-1 dispatchers, and Natividad healthcare staff among others reached a Tentative Agreement late Thursday evening with the County of Monterey on a new 3-year successor labor contract.

The Tentative Agreement, which is pending ratification by union members and the Monterey County Board of Supervisors includes the largest annual wage increases in at least 20 years - 12% over 3 years, as well as, longevity pay increases for workers with more than 10 years of service ranging from 2.5% to 5.5%.

The agreement adds Cesar Chavez Day (March 31), as a new paid holiday, beginning in March 2025. In addition, workers secured significant County contribution increases to healthcare insurance plans - a major union priority amidst the national attention related to healthcare costs in the Monterey County region.

"Our proposals to address healthcare costs and the vacancy crisis finally broke the log-jam with management. From public safety and child protective services to behavioral health support and road maintenance, our new agreement overcomes long-standing issues like healthcare and wages which will strengthen our ability to stabilize retention and build up a thriving Monterey County workforce", said Harriet Stevens, SEIU 521 Monterey County Chapter President.

The deal between the County and union averts a strike authorization vote which began on Tuesday, August 27 and was set to conclude on Thursday, August 29.

"Monterey County can be the best place to live, work and raise our families - our members wholeheartedly believe this and it's what guided our team to reach a fair agreement, " said Alicia Metters, Monterey County Social Worker and SEIU 521 Regional Vice President. "As county workers and members of this community, we have a responsibility to safeguard and expand the life-saving services our neighbors rely on - this new agreement invests in that commitment and I'm proud of the selfless unity we showed to achieve it."

A ratification vote by union members of the SEIU Local 521 is set to begin next week, followed by a ratification period by the Monterey County Board of Supervisors.

##

Service Employees International Union, Local 521 represents more than 3,500 public-sector workers across Monterey County. Under a Community First vision, we are committed to making sure the needs of our community, and the vital services we provide our community, come first. We believe our communities thrive when residents, leaders, and workers recognize that we are all in this together when it comes to our safety, health, and well-being.